

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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Last week: DJIA 42840.26 ▼ 987.80 2.25% NASDAQ 19572.60 ▼ 1.8% STOXX 600 502.19 ▼ 2.8% 10-YR. TREASURY ▼ 31/32, yield 4.522% OIL \$69.46 ▼ \$1.36 EURO \$1.0430 YEN 156.41

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **The downturn in U.S. agriculture** is depressing farmers' incomes and company profits, with weaker prices for commodities such as soybeans and wheat responsible for some of the pain. **A1**

◆ **Investors pouring money** into MicroStrategy as a leveraged play on bitcoin have demonstrated an allegiance to the company so feverish that at least one participant has called it a cult. **A1**

◆ **Commerce Secretary** Gina Raimondo said efforts to restrict China's access to technology haven't held back its progress, and federal funding for domestic innovation is what will keep the U.S. ahead of Beijing. **A2**

◆ **News Corp and Telstra** agreed to sell their jointly owned pay-TV company, Foxtel, to sports streaming service DAZN in a deal that values Foxtel at around \$2.1 billion. **B4**

◆ **Eli Lilly said the FDA** approved Zepbound for moderate-to-severe obstructive sleep apnea in adults with obesity. **B3**

◆ **Activist investor Palliser** doubled down on its call for a review of Rio Tinto's dual listing in London and Sydney. **B3**

◆ **The European Commission** unconditionally approved Nvidia's takeover of Israeli streamlining provider Run:ai. **B4**

◆ **Chevron and Woodside** agreed to an asset swap they said will sharpen their focus on the LNG operations they each run in Western Australia. **B3**

◆ **Aviation-services company AAR** agreed to pay more than \$55 million to resolve corruption-related investigations brought by the Justice Department and the SEC. **B3**

World-Wide

◆ **Private prisons** and other companies that provide detention services are preparing to cash in on what Trump has promised will be the largest domestic deportation operation in American history. **A1**

◆ **Trump openly** discussed provocative aspirations for U.S. territorial expansion, warning about taking over the Panama Canal and wresting control of Greenland from Denmark. **A8**

◆ **Two U.S. Navy pilots** ejected from their jet fighter over the Red Sea after being caught in an apparent case of friendly fire, U.S. Central Command said. **A9**

◆ **More teens are using** dangerously potent cannabis for intense highs and are ending up in emergency rooms after experiencing seizures, nausea and psychosis. **A3**

◆ **Democrats have yet** to land on a clear message or a leading messenger as Trump prepares to reoccupy the White House, leaving the president-elect mostly unchallenged. **A4**

◆ **Lara Trump said** she won't seek a U.S. Senate seat to represent Florida, ending speculation that she could succeed Marco Rubio in that position. **A2**

◆ **North Korea and Russia** are deepening their military cooperation, as Pyongyang increases the supply of arms to Moscow and receives cash and oil from the Kremlin in return. **A9**

◆ **Ukraine is supplementing** its arms procurement with weapons bought on a domestic open market. **A9**

◆ **Died: Rickey Henderson**, 65, base-stealing Hall of Famer. **A14**

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As Germans Mourn, Attack Raises New Questions



TRIBUTES: A man grieved at a memorial outside a church in Magdeburg on Sunday, two days after a driver plowed into a Christmas market, killing five people. Details about the suspect, a Saudi exile and anti-Islam activist, have left many perplexed. **A8**

U.S.'s Agricultural Downturn Hits Farmers, Company Profits

By PATRICK THOMAS

In northeastern North Dakota, Greg Amundson's 3,000-acre farm this year produced corn, soybeans, canola and rye. It also produced thousands of dollars in losses.

A bag of corn seed cost Amundson roughly \$150 a few years ago. Now he has a hard time finding one for less than \$230. Earlier this year it took three weeks to fix a mechanical problem on his combine that broke down during harvest, resulting in a four-figure repair bill.

"Everything is so expensive," Amundson said. "It's killing us."

Some farmers anticipate a boost from a multibillion-dollar bailout attached to the federal spending bill that passed in Congress and that President Biden signed over the weekend.

America has long provided subsidies to its farmers, dating back to the 1930s as a way to tackle rural poverty when a

quarter of the population lived on farms. Today, subsidies largely come in the form of insurance that enables farmers to secure loans needed to grow crops. Direct cash payments, while at times controversial, have been used to bolster farmers during agricultural downturns.

The U.S. farm sector finds itself in another rough patch. Net farm income declined 4% this year to \$141 billion after falling about 20% last year, according to the Agriculture Department. Weaker prices for commodities such as soybeans and wheat have weighed on farmers' earnings after growers in the U.S. and elsewhere reared big crops, swelling supplies. Their costs for essentials such as fertilizer and equipment are also higher.

"The ag industry is continuing to get weaker," Damon Audia, chief financial officer for farm-equipment maker Agco, said at a December investor meeting.

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Psychosis Patients Find New Hope

A classroom-style treatment teaches patients to live with the voices

By JULIE WERNAU

LOS ANGELES—Noah Hudnut's family had already spent \$150,000 on his psychiatric care when he was hauled in handcuffs by police to the emergency room of UCLA medical center.

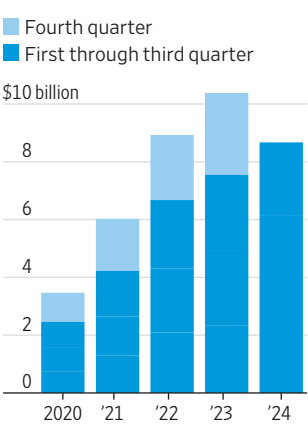
On top of the family's past expenses, Hudnut's insurance company was billed at least \$1,000 a day for his hospitalizations. Yet, his psychosis persisted. He believed he grew to gigantic proportions and knocked down the Twin Towers on 9/11, even though he had been 6 years old. He also was certain he caused the Covid-19 pandemic.

After Hudnut started driving erratically and throwing away valuables in a delusional state, his family called the police in November 2022, and he was taken to UCLA. While in the hospital, *Please turn to page A10*

Holiday Fraud Gets AI Boost

Scammers turn to AI for more sophisticated traps. **B4**

Amount U.S. consumers have lost to fraud, by year



Crypto Cult Fuels MicroStrategy Rise

Aiden Perez remixed a house-music track with audio from an interview with MicroStrategy co-founder Michael Saylor after the stock began its furious ascent last month.

By Gunjan Banerji, Rachel Louise Ensign and Jasmine Li

"People that use fiat currency...we call them poor," Saylor repeats on the track.

Perez, a 24-year-old software developer in Southern California, is an ardent believer in bitcoin who has dabbled in shares of MicroStrategy, the unprofitable tech company that Saylor morphed into a bitcoin-buying machine.

MicroStrategy's fans hold a feverish allegiance to the company that transcends the attention everyday investors pay to humdrum investments in their portfolios. Some spend their days trading memes of Saylor in groups like "Irresponsibly Long \$MSTR" on X or listening to fellow traders chat about the stock on podcasts and YouTube streams.

MicroStrategy is no ordinary company. *Please turn to page A6*

◆ **Ballmer is 'noninvesting' guru of investing**..... **B1**
◆ **Heard on the Street: Wild stock-market prices**..... **B10**

Letting Personnel Go Gets Impersonal Touch

By CHRISTOPHER OTTS AND CHIP CUTTER

A Detroit-area engineer with more than two decades at General Motors woke up one Friday in November to a predawn text on his work phone.

It carried an ominous message: Check your email.

By the time the engineer logged into his inbox, as the text instructed, his wife had already seen the news on television. The automaker was trimming another 1,000 jobs.

A form letter in the engineer's email informed him that his employment at GM was over, but no one from the company called him. There was no all-hands meeting. No one-on-one chat.

If he felt the need to speak with someone, the email gave a number for a call center. In the hybrid-work era,

some companies no longer feel obligated to deliver bad news face to face, or even over a Zoom call. A pink slip can come via a text message and email.

GM's approach shows that the ways companies dismiss workers are evolving, human-resources specialists say, during another season of end-of-year layoffs. In recent weeks, employers including Boeing, Sotheby's and others have announced job cuts.

The tactics companies use in dismissing workers vary. Boeing said in October that it would cut some 17,000 jobs, or about 10% of its global workforce. Shortly thereafter, Boeing let workers know that most layoff notices would go out in mid-November. Managers generally met with employees one on one, either in person or virtually, to break *Please turn to page A6*

INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL

Airline passengers are seeking better ways to catch some Zs while en route. **A12**



JASON GAY

Remembering Rickey Henderson, the base-stealing, run-scoring Hall of Famer. **A14**